THE REAGAN DIARIES

RONALD REAGAN

EDITED BY DOUGLAS BRINKLEY



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Chapter 1

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1981

1981

The Inaugural (Jan. 20) was an emotional experience but then the very next day it was "down to work." The first few days were long and hard—daily Cabinet meetings interspersed with sessions with Congressional leaders regarding our ec. plan.

Friday, March 20

[Meetings with Senator Jacob Javits (R-NY) and with former Japanese prime minister Takeo Fukuda.]

Forgot to say in yesterday's account that I met with Chai the Amb. P.R. of China. With him a man from Beijing. The Amb. got on the Taiwan subject—promised peaceful resolution of the problem, then made it plain he didn't feel we should sell weapons to Taiwan. I made it just as plain that we had an obligation we would fulfill. No harm done.

[Met with state legislators; swearing-in ceremony for Lee Annenberg as chief of protocol; spoke at Conservative Dinner.]

Thursday, October 29

Met with Huang Hua. There is a real push going on. China is virtually delivering an ultimatum re arms to Taiwan. I don't like ultimatums. We have a moral obligation & until a peaceful settlement is reached between the mainland & Taiwan we're going to meet that obligation.

Now to Bethesda for our check up & tomorrow to Camp David.

I won a purple heart. A Fleets E. before boarding Marine 1 and upon arrival at the Naval Hospt. right in for the Barium E. That is an experience I've never had before—Oh, I've had B.E.'s but they have a new procedure that's worse than March 30th.

One of the young ladies (Navy) made me a paper purple heart & I wore it.

Finally our 1st meal in 2 days.

Chapter 2

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1982

Friday, January 8–Sunday, January 10

[Complains of leak to press about secret meeting on Federalism.]

A team is off to Peking to tell them at 1st hand we're going to sell F5E's & some F104's to Taiwan. We're softening things a little. Taiwan really wants the more advanced F5G's—They'll have to come later.

Off to Camp David where it was only 8 degrees. We ran an old movie, "One Way Passage."—Kay Francis, Wm. Powell. It was wonderful. Sat. took a long walk in a snow storm then spent the afternoon getting a lot of mail done & tidying up a speech.

I've learned there is a China Lobby and it has its moles in the State Dept. The Post had a story on why we should cling to the P.R.C. & never mind Taiwan. A cartoon carried out the same theme. The timing is amazing because no word has been spoken about plans & I've told no one what my decision will be.

Sun. a short walk—with wind chill it was 52 degrees below zero.

Monday, January 11

Repub. House leaders came down to the W.H.—Except for Jack Kemp they are h--l bent on new taxes & cutting the defense budget. Looks like a heavy year ahead.

Al Haig seems to have won a moral victory in Brussels on NATO vs. Poland & the Soviets.

Press running wild with talk that I reversed myself on Taiwan because we're only selling them F5E's & F104's. I think the China Lobby in State Dept. is selling this line to appease the P.R.C. which doesn't want us to sell them anything.

The planes we're offering are better than anything the P.R.C. has. Later on if more sophistication is needed we'll upgrade & sell them F5G's.

[Reception for the Hoover Institute board of governors.]

Friday, March 26

Briefing on Soviet Ec. They are in very bad shape and if we can cut off their credit they'll have to yell "Uncle" or starve. We had cabinet meetings on our own economy. It is imperative that we get further budget cuts. So far the Dems. aren't budging. Our strategy is to move them toward bipartisan agreement on the entitlements—the only real savings must be found there.

[Telephoned Ted Cummings, U.S. ambassador to Austria, regarding his health.]

Called Geo. Schultz in S.A. and asked him to do a mission for us in Europe and Japan. What a nice man—busy as he is he agreed.

Jim Brady came in—we had a small wine taste of some 19th century wines brought by a friend of his—a dealer.

Al and I are on opposite sides I'm afraid about China. He wants to make concessions which in my view betray our pledge to Taiwan. We'll have to work it out.

Had lunch with about 80 or 100 Black Clergy. I think they understand us better now.

Monday, March 29

[Addressed National Association of Realtors.]

Meetings with Al Haig about China and Taiwan. State wanted to send a paper to the P.R.C. and letters from me because we are about to send mil. equipment and spare parts to Taiwan. I objected to some of the terms they wanted in these papers—the note of almost apology to the P.R.C. I'm convinced the Chinese will respect us more if we politely tell them we have an obligation to the people and Taiwan and no one is going to keep us from meeting it. We didn't send the papers.

Tuesday, May 4

[British take losses in war.]

Turned State dept. down on a message they wanted me to send our Ambassador in China urging him to have informal talks with Chinese preceding George Bush's arrival. The talks were to soften the Taiwan issue some more. We can't do that—the Taiwanese have proven their friendship.

[Cabinet meeting regarding sugar imports; met with Republican members of the House Budget Committee.]

Dick Wirthlin reported in. My speech was to a smaller TV audience than usual. Probably due to its last min. nature and no promotion. But people are confused on the whole budget issue and my ratings are way down.

[Dinner for the Congressional Campaign Committee.]

Wednesday, May 12

[Visit from President João Baptista Figueiredo of Brazil.]

Al H.- George Bush and I lunched on the patio and heard about George's trip to China. The P.R.C. is really obsessed with our continuing to be friendly to Taiwan. Well there isn't going to be any change on our part.

Francis Albert (Sinatra) came by with the Multiple Sclerosis Mother and Father of the year. He's heading up their fundraising drive—"F.S. for M.S." What a cruel disease—a young mother getting around in a walker—has a handsome little boy. Louis Unser—brother of the Indianapolis 500 champ—(Louis was a race driver too), he's in a wheelchair. He has a lovely little girl.

[State dinner; President João Baptista Figueiredo said that he'd heard British intended to attack Argentine mainland bases.]

Friday, June 18

[Reason for optimism regarding Lebanon; report that Vatican working to reestablish ***relations with Libya.]***

Met to finally decide whether to lift sanctions on pipe line material to Soviets. Cabinet very divided. I ruled we would not remove sanctions. There hadn't been the slightest move on the Soviets part to change their evil ways.

Barry Goldwater came to see me—he's upset by rumors that I'm going to dump Taiwan. I convinced him there is no way I'll ever do that.

[NRC reception in the East Room; left for Camp David; impressed by Clint Eastwood's work on film Firefox *(1982).* **Saturday, June 19–Sunday, June 20:** *riding and swimming; prepared for upcoming meeting with Prime Minister Menachem Begin; returned to W.H.; dinner with Maureen and Dennis.]*

Friday, July 30

Met with group of Sen's. who wanted to be re-assured that I was not abandoning Taiwan. Kasten was the main spokesman. I think they are now satisfied.

Did a video tape for King Hussein—celebration of his 30th year as King.

Most important of all—a meeting with deputy F.M. of Egypt Ali. He and his associates wanted a commitment from us to recognize and negotiate with the P.L.O. We pointed out that while they asked that of us—so far Egypt has refused to take any of the P.L.O. fighters in Beirut. It is Egypt as well as some other Arab states who are destroying the P.L.O. by refusing to take them in even temporarily while we settle the Lebanon problem.

Rain & thunder but we made it to Camp David where it was also foggy and raining. Saw "The World According to Garp."—good show.

Tuesday, August 17

P.L.O. out of Beirut looks much closer. Press and TV with a leak from State Dept. has gone crazy declaring our joint communiqué with P.R.C. of China is a betrayal of Taiwan. Truth is we are standing with Taiwan and the P.R.C. made all the concessions.

Met and lunched with Chairman Moe [Samuel K. Doe]—head of Liberia. Spent rest of day calling & meeting with people (Congress) on tax package.

[Stock market responded positively to speech; meeting in order to calm concerns of congressmen and senators anxious over relations with Taiwan.]

Chapter 4

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1984

Tuesday, January 10

Premier Zhao (P.R.C.) arrived. We had a formal S. Lawn ceremony with

full military honors. The day was freezing cold which held off a rain that didn't fall till around noon. Zhao is a likeable fellow & a very capable one. China communism makes room for some pvt. enterprise etc. In our Oval Office meeting he took off on Taiwan being the block to full relationship & even hinted that if peaceful negotiations didn't resolve the problem he might have to use other means. I told him we wanted a resolution of the problem but any use of force would change our relationship beyond repair. We got along fine from then on.

Sens. Tower & Warner came by to report on their middle east trip. Both went, inclined to believe we should bug out of Beirut. Both came back convinced the Marines should stay & that withdrawal would be a disaster. This is going to be of great help to us with the Cong.

[Senator Pete Wilson (R-CA) visited to campaign for government purchase of F-20 Northrop fighter planes; state dinner, music by Isaac Stern.]

Tuesday, April 24

Off to Guam—a farewell ceremony as we left Hickam field. Barry Goldwater & a few other Sens. were there on their way back to Wash. after a trip to Taiwan. Barry is upset about my trip & can't hide it. He seems to think I'm selling out our friends on Taiwan. He should know better. I've made it very plain to the leaders of the P.R.C. that we will not forsake old friends in order to make new ones.

Saturday, April 28

Another breakfast meeting because this was Big Casino day—my meeting with Chairman Deng. Nancy went with me for the informal opening. Deng—who has a sense of humor invited her to come back to China without me.

Then in our meeting he really waded in critical of our mid-east policy, our treatment of the developing nations etc. & our disarmament failure. He touched a nerve—when it was my turn I corrected him with facts & figures & I meant it. Funny thing happened—he warmed up although he did bring up Taiwan (the only one who did). I told him that was their problem to be worked out—but it must be worked out peacefully. We broke for lunch (he was host) & though it was scheduled to be a working lunch it became a pleasant social event instead.

After lunch we picked up Nancy & were off to the Great Wall. All the way we waved our arms off at the crowds lining the streets to see us & even in the villages after we got out of the country.

The Wall has an amazing effect even though you've seen photos & movies of it. There is a feeling I can't describe when you stand on it & see it disappear over the mountains in both directions.

This evening we hosted a dinner for a mixed group of Americans & Chinese plus Premier Zhao etc. at the Great Wall Hotel which is an American, Chinese partnership venture. The dinner was American—roast turkey.